

"TUM'S STORY"

By Jim Bishop

Tum Whitlow was the ugliest boy in Red Rock, Oklahoma. He was also the meanest. That is, if you didn't count Brady Hoff, the town bully. Some say he was mean, (Tum that is) because he was so ugly. "Boy howdie, if I was that ugly, I'd be mean too." Pert Snodgrass used to say. Others said having a name like Tum didn't help none either.

"What the heck kinduva' name is that for a boy, anyways?" some would ask.

There were all kinds of stories about Tum's name. One version was that it was a nickname and was short for Tumbleweed, which was supposed to be his real name. It was supposed to be the name his Momma gave him when he was born. She died later when he was three years old. After that, his Pa took to calling him Tum.

"Hell, it weren't Tumbleweed he was named. More'n likely it war Tumblebug," old Tom Howard would always say in his wheezy, chewing tobacco flavored laugh. That remark always brought loud guffaws from whoever was around to hear it said. They'd laugh even though they'd heard it many times before.

Kids who grew up with Tum knew better than to say anything about his name. You never, never asked Tum about his real name. That was a touchy and forbidden subject with him. You only asked him once. He wouldn't say a word to you. He'd just walk over and punch you in the nose, then turn away and walk off. That was what happened if you were a boy. Girls, he would just stomp on one of their feet and while they were hopping around off balance, crying and sniveling, he'd push them down.

Now about the ugly part. The whole left side of Tum's face was all sunk in and scarred up. His left eye was pulled out of line and was sorta' froze in a permanent, unblinking stare. The scar tissue on his cheek pulled at his mouth and caused him to look like he was always sneering at something. All of this was the result of his getting kicked by a spooky mule when he was ten years old. His Pa had this old brown mule that was especially cantankerous about anybody getting in behind it. Tum had brought the mule back to the barn late one afternoon, after a full day of plowing. Tum was hot and tired, and as a result he was careless. He had taken the sweat soaked harness off of the mule and had turned to hang it up, when it slipped from his hands. As he bent over to pick up the harness, that mule kicked him clear across the barn and almost into the next county. Luckily for Tum, it was a glancing blow. Otherwise, according to the Doc, Tum would have been kicked into the next life.

The blow was enough, however to do considerable damage to the side of his face and to his eye. They rushed him to the hospital in Oklahoma City where he spent several weeks getting over his accident. The Doctors in that hospital worked on him, fixing his face and eye as best they could. When he finally came home, he still had a big bandage over one side of his head, and he didn't come out of the house much. Being summer time when it happened, he didn't miss any school, just some of the hard work on his Pa's farm. He had to go into the city several times that summer, having his bandaged changed and getting his face taken care of. When school took up in September, Tum didn't want to go. His Pa told him in no uncertain terms that he was going to school, if he had to kick his behind every step of the way.

That first day, Tum rode into town on the school bus, keeping his head down so he wouldn't have to look anybody straight in the face. He didn't say much to anyone. He did manage to mumble a, "Hullo, Allen." at me when I spoke to him. He and I had been friendly enough, after I had gotten punched in the nose for asking about his name. No one said a word about his face that first day on his return to school. Nor did anyone ever mention it to him directly, as long as they knew him. Tum had to live with that awful scar, and by golly so did we. Of course, Tum had to speak to his teachers when they'd ask him something in class, and you could tell it just about stretched him to the limit when he would have to stand up in the front of the class and read a report or something. Tum was stubborn, so he toughed it out. Gradually, he accepted his condition and began to walk normal again, holding his head up and not looking down for anybody. His scar became a badge of courage and he dared anyone to make some remark about it. The girls would usually turn their heads when they'd meet him coming down the halls at school. A few of us boys tried to be friendly with him, but he kept mostly to himself after school.

Folks in town would cluck their tongues when they saw Tum growing up but never able to outgrow the damage to his face. "Ain't it a shame what happened to that boy?" they would ask one another.

"That kid's ornery enough, but 'dout nobody deserve that ta' happen to 'em."

"Th' Lord's truth."

Tum had been just playful mean before he got kicked by the mule, but the mean he was, was nothing to the mean he became. He had been mad at the world for losing his Momma. Now he was mad at the world because of his ugly, scarred up face. Every year he became a little more ornery mean.

"That boy's gonna' come to a bad end." Pop Brantley would say whenever he walked past his barber shop. Pop eagerly told his customers about Tum's latest mean stunt he had pulled off. "'Put a whole gallon of syrup in Tom Hensley's new

combine engine 'cause he wouldn't hire him for the wheat harvest this year. That he did."

Or.

"I hear he shot one of his Pa's rams right between the horns when it butted him the other day. Mean. Oh how that boy is mean."

"That's Lord's truth."

Whatever was said about Tum as he grew older, very little was ever good. He didn't finish high school with the rest of us. His Pa got to drinking and the farm started going downhill. One day, he just packed a suitcase and caught the Trailways bus for Oklahoma City. We later heard he got a job working in a machine shop. He would come home once or twice a year to see his Pa, then go back to the city.

I went into the Army and spent three years in the infantry in Europe during the war. After I got my discharge and came back home, I asked about Tum. No one had seen him for several years. We knew he wouldn't have been able to get into any branch of the service with his bad eye and injured face, but no one seemed to know what had become of him.

Several years later, Tum did come back home. His Pa had died and he had to settle up his debts and sell what was left of the farm. By that time I was married, had three kids and had been elected as County Clerk. Out of curiosity one day, I had looked up the Birth Records on when Tum was born. I wanted to find out the truth about his real name. We were both about the same age, so it didn't take too long for me to locate the right year and find the volume with Tum's birth recorded in it. It read:

Born to Matthew B. Whitlow and Amy Tumlinson Whitlow
November 21, 1922. A son, Tumlinson John Whitlow

So it wasn't Tumbleweed after all. And it certainly wasn't Tumblebug either. It was Tumlinson, his Momma's family name.

When I saw him he was coming out of the Piggly Wiggly with a sack of groceries in each arm. He looked at me and nodded, acknowledging that he'd recognized me.

"How are you Tumlinson?" I asked, putting as much sincerity in my voice as possible. He looked surprised. I was hoping he wouldn't be offended at my using his real name, or at the fact that I had obviously had to check the records to find out what it was. He stopped when we walked abreast of one another and I thought to myself, "If he starts to set those bags of groceries down, you are fixin' to get yourself punched in the nose again."

The look of surprise on his face slowly changed into a crooked grin as he looked at me and answered,

"I'm fine Allen. Just fine."

He walked on and that was the last time I ever saw him.